



FREE GUIDE · FOR TATTOO & BODY-ART STUDIOS

The Tattoo Studio's Guide to Compliant Waste Disposal.

Needles and blood-contaminated waste are regulated medical waste — even in a studio.

DEA-REGISTERED

EPA-COMPLIANT

NO CONTRACT

CERTIFICATE OF DESTRUCTION

Compliance, made simple.

Yes, it's regulated medical waste.

Tattoo and body-art studios generate two regulated streams most owners underestimate — used needles and blades (sharps) and blood-contaminated materials (biohazard). A health inspection can shut you down over either. The good news: it's simple to handle compliantly. This guide covers both, plus the everyday waste that isn't regulated.

The good news

One vendor can take your sharps and biohazard by prepaid mail-back kit, with a Certificate of Destruction and no contract — simple enough to manage from the front desk.

AT A GLANCE

Who regulates what.

Agency	What it covers in your practice
OSHA	Bloodborne Pathogens Standard — sharps handling, containers, and annual staff training.
EPA	RCRA — hazardous pharmaceutical waste identification, segregation, and destruction.
DEA	Controlled substances — non-retrievable destruction and DEA Form 41 documentation.
DOT	Safe shipping of regulated medical and pharmaceutical waste in transit.
State	Health-department and environmental rules that vary by state.

THE STREAMS

Every stream, in depth.

Below is each regulated stream your practice produces — what belongs in it, what does not, the rule behind it, how to dispose of it, and a tip to stay clean.

WASTE STREAM 01

Sharps

Your primary regulated stream — anything that pierces skin.

GOES IN THIS STREAM

- Tattoo & single-use needles
- Razor blades
- Used cartridges & tips

DOES NOT GO HERE

- Bloody gauze (biohazard)
- Expired meds (pharmaceutical)
- Non-sharp packaging

THE RULE · OSHA Bloodborne Pathogens Standard — FDA-cleared, puncture-resistant containers, no overfilling, annual training.

DISPOSE WITH · Sharps mail-back kit.

Tip

Replace containers at the fill line and keep them upright, closable, and out of reach.

WASTE STREAM 02

Biohazard / regulated medical waste

Blood- and ink-contaminated materials from every session.

GOES IN THIS STREAM

- Blood-contaminated gauze & wipes
- Used ink caps with blood
- Contaminated gloves & barrier film

DOES NOT GO HERE

- Sharps (sharps kit)
- Lightly soiled everyday items
- Expired meds (pharmaceutical)

THE RULE · OSHA plus your state's medical-waste rules — red bags, labeling, treatment/destruction, and retained documentation.

DISPOSE WITH · Biohazard mail-back kit.

Tip

Only visibly blood/OPIM-contaminated items are red-bag waste — over-classifying wastes money.

WASTE STREAM 03

Pharmaceutical waste

Any expired numbing or aftercare products with medical ingredients.

GOES IN THIS STREAM

- Expired topical anesthetics (lidocaine)
- Expired medical aftercare products
- Samples

DOES NOT GO HERE

- Controlled substances (own kit)
- RCRA-hazardous drugs (own kit)
- Sharps

THE RULE · Do not drain-dispose; segregate hazardous drugs; destroy with documentation.

DISPOSE WITH · Pharmaceutical waste mail-back kit.

Tip

Keep any hazardous or controlled drugs separate — they each have their own path.

YOUR CHECKLIST

The tattoo studio compliance checklist.

- ☐ Needles, blades, and cartridges in FDA-cleared sharps containers, replaced at the fill line.
- ☐ Blood-contaminated wipes, gauze, and ink caps red-bagged as biohazard.
- ☐ Expired numbing agents destroyed as pharmaceutical waste, not trashed.
- ☐ Cross-contamination controls and barrier film in place.
- ☐ Staff trained on bloodborne pathogens per your state/local rules.
- ☐ Certificates of Destruction retained for inspections.

QUESTIONS TATTOO STUDIOS ASK

Your tattoo studio questions, answered.

Do tattoo shops really need medical waste disposal?

Yes. Used needles are sharps and blood-contaminated materials are regulated medical waste — the same rules as a clinic, enforced by your health department.

How do we dispose of tattoo needles and cartridges?

In an FDA-cleared sharps container and a sharps mail-back kit — never the regular trash.

What about bloody wipes and used ink caps?

Blood-contaminated items are biohazard / red-bag waste — dispose through a biohazard kit.

Is expired numbing cream regulated?

Expired lidocaine or medical numbing agents are pharmaceutical waste — destroyed with documentation, not trashed.

Do we need a contract?

No — no contract, no minimums; buy kits as you need them.

THE EASY WAY

Handle it with mail-back.

Easy Rx Cycle ships prepaid mail-back kits sized to a tattoo studio — fill, seal, and mail them back. We destroy the contents at our DEA-registered facility and return a Certificate of Destruction that satisfies your health inspector. No pickups, no contract.

QUICK REFERENCE · WHICH KIT FOR WHICH STREAM

Waste stream	The right path
Needles, blades, cartridges	Sharps mail-back kit
Blood-contaminated waste / ink caps	Biohazard mail-back kit
Expired numbing agents	Pharmaceutical waste kit
Clean packaging / paper	Regular waste (not regulated)

Prefer pickup, or higher volume?

Mail-back suits nearly every studio. Running a large or multi-artist shop with high volume? We'll size a program — get a quote at easyrxcycle.com/get-a-quote or call 501-904-2929.

WHY TATTOO STUDIOS CHOOSE EASY RX CYCLE

- No contract, no minimums — buy as you need
- Flat-rate pricing — no fuel or hidden surcharges
- One vendor for every stream you generate
- DEA-registered, EPA- & OSHA-aligned destruction
- A Certificate of Destruction on every single order



Ready to simplify your tattoo studio waste?

Shop mail-back kits with prices, or get a custom quote for pickup and higher volume. No contract, cancel anytime.

501-904-2929 · sales@easyrxcycle.com · easyrxcycle.com/shop